18.6 EDI Standards

The standard is the most critical part of the entire EDI. Since EDI is the data transmission and information exchange in the form of an agreed message format, it is important to develop a unified EDI standard. The EDI standard is mainly divided into the following aspects: basic standards, code standards, message standards, document standards, management standards, application standards, communication standards and security standards.

The first industry-specific EDI standard was the TDCC published by the Transportation Data coordinating Committee in 1975. Then other industries started developing unique standards based on their individual needs. E.g. WINS in the warehousing industry.

After the development of the two major regional EDI standards and a few years after trial, the two standards began to integrate and conduct research and development of common EDI standards. Subsequently, the United Nations Economic Commission for Europe (UN/ECE/WP.4) hosted the task of the development of international EDI standards. In 1986, UN/EDIFACT is officially proposed. The most widely used EDI message standards are the United Nations EDIFACT and the ANSI X12.

18.7 UN/EDIFACT

United Nations / Electronic Data Interchange for Administration, Commerce and Transport (UN / EDIFACT) is an international EDI - standard developed under the supervision of the United Nations. In 1987, the UN / EDIFACT syntax rules were approved as ISO: ISO9735 standard by the International Organization for Standardization. See Figure 18.4

EDIFACT includes a set of internationally agreed standards, catalogs and guidelines for electronic exchange of structured data between independent computer systems.



Figure: 18.4 UN/EDIFACT

It is a cross-industry, standard data format of electronic data for commercial transactions. Maintenance and further development of this standard goes through the United Nations Center for Trade Facilitation and Electronic Business (UN/CEFACT), which is affiliated to the UN Economic Commission for Europe (UNECE).

EDIFACT directories

The versions of EDIFACT are also called as directories. These EDIFACT directories will be revised twice a year; on 1st April and 1st October to include new or update existing EDIFACT messages. EDIFACT directories have names like D.18B

(D stands for Directory, 18 is the year and A/B indicates the month of release)

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